

The 5 Triggers

A work aid for your next learning project. Run any course through the five, in about ten minutes.

The brain is actively trying to forget. Forgetting is free. Each trigger is a way to put the tag on your content, so the brain keeps it.

1. HUMOR

Ripolles et al., 2016; Garner, 2006

What it is: The brain is always predicting what comes next. A joke is a nice surprise, the prediction breaks in a good way, and that surprise releases dopamine, the brain's signal to keep what it just learned.

In your next project: Use humor that carries the point, not humor that sits next to it. If you can remove the joke without losing the lesson, the joke is decoration. When the joke is the lesson, the laugh does the remembering for you.

Quick check:

- ☐ Is there at least one moment of genuine lightness or wit?
- ☐ Does the humor carry the teaching point (remove the joke, lose the lesson)?
- ☐ Is the funniest moment also one of the most important moments?



2. EMOTION

What it is: Emotions are the narrative we give to events. The amygdala signals the hippocampus when something feels important, and that is the tag that decides what gets stored.

In your next project: Emotion does not mean drama, it means stakes. Let the learner feel what happens when it goes wrong, before you teach the right way. And remember the positive side: showing what doing it right looks like, a real testimonial, a real outcome, tags the memory just as well.

Quick check:

- ☐ Does the course show the real cost of getting it wrong, before teaching the right way?
- ☐ Would a learner feel something in the first 60 seconds?
- ☐ Are consequences shown through people and situations, not policy statements?



3 RELEVANCE

Loewenstein, 1994

What it is: The brain gives attention to what feels like its own world. When the learner sees his own job, his own tools, his own situation, the brain says: this is about me, pay attention.

In your next project: Build the learning inside the learner's real world, their actual workplace, their real scenarios, even their culture and language. Bonus: when the learning looks like the real workplace, the workplace itself becomes the trigger for the memory, and it comes back exactly at the moment of need.

Quick check:

- ☐ Does it open with the learner's problem, not objectives or a disclaimer?
- ☐ Are scenarios set in the learner's actual world (their role, tools, situations)?
- ☐ Would a learner say 'this is about my job' in the first two minutes?



4. DUAL CODING

Paivio, 1971 & 1986; Mayer

What it is: The brain has two channels, one for words and one for visuals. Using both together multiplies memory, but only when each channel carries something the other cannot.

In your next project: If the visual just repeats the narration, you used one channel twice, and it can even overload. Let the words explain, and let the visual show what words cannot describe: a relationship, a process, a feeling.

Quick check:

- ☐ Do the visuals show something the narration does not say?
- ☐ If you muted the audio, would the visuals still teach something?
- ☐ Are there zero scenes where on-screen text simply repeats the voiceover?



5. DIFFERENT

von Restorff, 1933; Hunt, 1995

What it is: The official name is distinctiveness. The brain remembers what breaks the pattern, and blurs everything that looks the same. Same gets forgotten.

In your next project: Look at your whole library, not one course. If everything comes from the same templates and stock characters, it all lands in one grey folder called 'work training'. Choose where to break the pattern, and today, with the tools we have, looking different is no longer a budget question.

Quick check:

- ☐ Does this course look noticeably different from the rest of your library?
- ☐ Is there one moment a learner would describe to a colleague?
- ☐ Without the logo, could learners tell it apart from your other courses?

